

KHAUF (2025)

Adeptly written by Smita Singh and shot and co-directed by Pankaj Kumar, the chills in this supernatural horror series are close to home, as Singh touches on the pervasive patriarchy and misogyny that women contend with daily. "I think horror is the next *Dhurandhar*," she says. "I've lost count of how many producers have knocked on my door asking for a horror."



SHAITAAN (2024)

Writer Ameel Keeyan Khan penned what was the last successful Indian horror outing in cinemas, about a family dealing with their daughter falling prey to black magic. "In horror, it is all left to the imagination," he says. "I find it an optimistic genre in that something unexplainable exists and you dig into its mystery. It makes life more interesting."

with disturbed families and vengeful ghosts, haunted houses and crucifying curses. Last year, there was only one Hindi horror film worth talking about—the Aditya Dhar-produced *Baramulla*, an unsettling, sociopolitical thriller about a police officer investigating child abductions.

CLASSY OR TRASHY?

One major factor in the scarcity of horror in Hindi cinema is the genre's lingering B movie reputation, a hangover, perhaps of the Ramsay oeuvre of the 1980s and early '90s. For Smita Singh, writer of Indian OTT's finest long-format horror outing in *Khauf* (2025, Amazon Prime Video), about a woman who moves into a haunted hostel room, their aesthetic may have been tacky, but they knew the source of "visceral horror". It was evident in Saamri, the main attraction of the Ramsay film *Purana Mandir*: a hulking monster played by the 6-feet-5-inch-tall actor Aniruddh Agarwal, known for his deep voice and distorted facial features. Well-done horror, Singh says, has "to keep people on the edge of their seats. You have to let go of self-serious examination. By over-intellectualising horror, we lose its pulp nature".

Another reason for the scarcity of horror films in India, according to Singh, is that producers presume audiences aren't ready "to sit and deal with real anxiety, one that's recognisable in their own world". Actor-producer Sohum Shah agrees. "We don't trust our audience. There's not much experimentation happening in the genre," he says. In *Khauf*, Singh taps into unnerving territory with an encounter between a malevolent ghost and a woman traumatised by a sexual assault. There are no gags in the series, no dance numbers or gimmicks. "With horror, one doesn't need to chase stars, it thrives on good writing and craft," she adds. *Obsession*, after all, saw two responses among the audience, young men identifying with the portrayal of a clingy, crazy girlfriend and women focusing on the film's commentary on consent.

When writer Aamil Keeyan Khan pitched horror thrillers, he too faced reluctance. "People would make faces," he says. "There's *bhed chaal*, this herd mentality, where people don't want to bet on stories," he complains. Yet he has